And so is this—eternalism, the block universe—the only way left for us to conceive of the world? Must we think of the world with past, present, and future like a single present, all existing in the same way? That nothing changes, and that everything is motionless? Is change only an illusion?

No, I really don't think so.

The fact that we cannot arrange the universe like a single orderly sequence of times does not mean that nothing changes. It means that changes are not arranged in a single orderly succession: the temporal structure of the world is more complex than a simple single linear succession of instants. This does not mean that it is nonexistent or illusory.[62]

The distinction between past, present, and future is not an illusion. It is the temporal structure of the world. But the temporal structure of the world is not that of presentism. The temporal relations between events are more complex than we previously thought, but they do not cease to exist on account of this. The relations of filiation do not establish a global order, but this does not make them illusory. If we are not all in single file, it does not follow that there are no relations between us. Change, what happens—this is not an illusion. What we have discovered is that it does not follow a global order.[63]

Let's return to the question with which we began: What "is real"? What "exists"?

The answer is that this is a badly put question, signifying everything and nothing. Because the adjective "real" is ambiguous; it has a thousand meanings. The verb "to exist" has even more. To the question "Does a puppet whose nose grows when he lies exist?" it is possible to reply: "Of course he exists! It's Pinocchio!"; or: "No, it doesn't, he's only part of a fantasy dreamed up by Collodi."

Both answers are correct, because they are using different meanings of the verb "to exist."

There are so many different usages of the verb, different ways in which we can say that a thing exists: a law, a stone, a nation, a war, a character in a play, the god (or gods) of a religion to which we do not belong, the God of the religion to which we do belong, a great love, a number. . . . Each one of these entities "exists" and "is real" in a sense different from all the others. We can ask ourselves in what sense something exists or not (Pinocchio exists as a literary character but not as far as any Italian register office is concerned), or if a thing exists in a determined way (does a rule exist preventing you from "castling" in chess, if you have already moved the castle?). To ask oneself in general "what exists" or "what is real" means only to ask how you would like to use a verb and an adjective.[64] It's a grammatical question, not a question about nature.